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Disha IISER Pune

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Coordinators' speaks for Spread the Smile

"The month of February is like Christmas in IISER, where we become like Santa Claus and go to villages to give the kids there the most important gift in their lives - some moments of happiness"

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An Editor's Comments

When you look around at our society, you will see many children lagging behind in education, due to either social and economic standards, or because of quality of education provided to them. Many people pass by thinking that 'The situation is too bad, it'll never change'. Rather than helping this count increase, we saw the need of forming a formal organization as a fact, we decided to do our bit.

Following this ideology, few of our seniors started teaching kids of 9th and 10th in Someshwarwadi. As the volunteers' count increased, the need was felt for starting a formal organization. Hence 'Disha' came into being. Now as we can see, it is an organization with many activities and volunteers participating in it. So, how was this journey of Disha? How did it grow from a simple seed to a mammoth tree?

After Someshwarwadi, Laman Vasti centre was opened. The on-going construction work in IISER has brought many migrants onto the campus whose kids are deprived of any sort of formal education, hence the construction site was also included in abhyasikha centres. Disha had also started another centre at 'Janwadi', but was closed due to various difficulties.

If this is the case in a big city like Pune, then one cannot even imagine what the situation would be like in remote villages. General consensus agrees to the fact that educational facilities and resources in such villages are low. So in order improve the situation, Outreach program and Spread the Smile activities were started. To sustain a large organization, one has to have proper resources. Hence Resource team was created, which works behind the scenes and provides assistance to the abhyasikas and the outreach team.

A change in the society obviously needs long term effort. Everybody talks about it, but only a handful are a part of it. We, at Disha strive for it.

By Suvidyakumar Homkar

Vigyan Mela 2014



Disha organizes Vigyan Mela every year in January. The objective of 'Vigyan Mela' is bringing the children living in Laman Vasti and Someshwarwadi together and expose them to different kinds of activities not related to their studies, which will improve their other skills. This year (2014), it was held on 18th and 19th January.

On 18th, for the inauguration, Dr. Nishikant Subhedar, Professor at IISER Pune, was the chief guest. He explained the importance of rational thinking in day-to-day life in very simple language. Children also enjoyed

the 'Juggling' performance by IISER Pune students. Then, some selected children in Someshwarwadi presented their speech on different topics. This activity seemed to improve the confidence level in those children.

On 19th, we conducted other activities. Unlike last year, this year we tried to focus on science related activities. For the children in 6th to 10th standard, there was a session of demonstration of various scientific experiments, a periscope making

session, which children found very interesting, solving puzzles in mathematics like Hanoi's Tower, Tangram puzzles, some number puzzles. We conducted Banner making competition for which the topic was "Stop Pollution (Pradushan Thambava)". Children came up with many innovative ideas. For the children in 1st to 5th standard, there was a session in which they played many interesting games like solving jigsaw puzzles, memory game, origami, creating different designs from many colourful small geometrical shapes. We also conducted drawing competition, which had a good response.

The event ended by the prize distribution ceremony for which Dr. Guruswamy was the chief guest. He works at NCL, Pune

The event could have been organized in a better way in the context of maintaining discipline among the children. We could include some more interesting puzzles in Mathematics session. Compared to last year, this year 'Vigyan Mela' had more science related activities. Mathematics session, elocution competition and model making were the most remarkable events. There was a good number of participation from girls. They dominated the elocution competition. It was a different experience this time, looking at it through the specs of a coordinator.

By Prachi Atmasiddha



Update on Someshwarwadi Abhyashika

A group of our enthusiastic and inspired seniors decided one day to teach the kids of the nearby vasti, Someshwarwadi. That is how Disha began. It is the oldest abhyasikha and hence, has a very loyal group of kids who continue to come through the years. Owing to this fact, we have been able to build up on the previously laid foundations in Basic English alphabets and elementary maths.



The aim for the year 2013-2014 was not only to continue to strengthen these foundations, but also to teach them science. But, we soon realised that they didn't know many scientific Marathi words which were needed to understand the concepts in their textbooks. Hence, we started teaching Marathi first instead of science.

We work with children in the age group 7-11 during the weekdays. The first two days are reserved for Marathi, the

next two for Mathematics and the last day for English. Unfortunately, age doesn't directly correlate to knowledge. So, groups are made on the basis of abilities.

Great commitment from the volunteers and enthusiasm from the children has made this year a good one. We hope to maintain it that way!

By P.M. Shreenidhi

Reopening of Laman Vasti Abhyashika

Laman vasti is one of the abhyashikhas run by Disha for the children of Laman tanda, a fairly large colony located near Someshwarwadi. The main aim of this abhyashika is to support children in their studies and help to pursue good education. Apart from studies we also focused on extra curriculum activities and some skill development activities also.

The abhyashika was closed frequently due to various problems in the vasti. The inhabitants of Laman thanda are mainly labourers, alcohol brewers and small workers, vendors etc. Most of them are uneducated and struggle hard for their livelihood, which in turn also affects the education of the children living there. Disha started an abhyashika here in order to improve their educational condition. Despite several problems the abhyashika has managed to establish there and work for the students there.

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room located at the start of both vastis (namely, Someshwarwadi and Laman vasti). Despite the long gap, many students showed interest and attended the class. The abhyashika now has an average of 25 students. At the start there were only 9 volunteers and we had to limit the number of working days to four.

The main focus of the abhyashika for now is to create a good base for the children in English and maths. The new teaching technique adapted considers all students, regardless of their class or age, and aims on providing the essential base for everyone. Recently 4 more volunteers have joined the abhyashika. The classes are now regular. The future plans are to introduce more subjects and also to start a free tuition provisions for 9th, 10th standard students.

By Prasanth P.

The abhyashika has again been reopened on this February, at a new class

Coordinators' Speak for Spread the Smile

Spread the Smile '14 was organised in the month of January and February by the Outreach team of Disha. It was aimed at spreading the joy of science and inspiring children to take up higher education. It also gives the volunteers a chance to take a peek into life in rural India by staying in a village around Pune.



Spread the smile '14 expanded to eight centers in seven villages: Mangdhari, Male, Kadadhe, Kanewari, Kurungi, Kusgaon, Kondanpur and volunteers from ten colleges.

By Sharvaree Vadgama

The month of February is like Christmas in IISER, where we become like Santa Claus and go to villages to give the kids there the most important gift in their lives - some moments of happiness. In return we get an experience of a lifetime.

There are lots of interesting experiences I had during Spread the Smile this year - like when I started my game theory presentation, a boy came up to me and said, "Aapko teen patti sikhaun?", or the time we crossed a bridge made of pipelines, or when ten of us sat down together and literally cried (because the

food was extremely tasty and spicy) while we were stuffing ourselves during lunch and dinner time.

But my best experience happened when two boys were showing me their village. They decided to climb up trees and I picked a slightly tall tree to climb up. The kids could simply not believe that a person living in the city could climb a tree. One of the boys kept on shouting, "Bhaiya aap chad jaoge?" When I actually climbed it, they were simply amazed. The boys kept telling people that I climbed "that huge tree" (in their words). It felt like I had got a big break-through in something, or like I was some kind of messiah for them.

By Kunal Mozumdar

On my trip to the village of Mangdhari for Spread the Smile, I was surprised to get such huge support and co-operation from the principal and the local villagers, as I had heard from many volunteers that the teachers in many villages don't co-operate and hence was a bit nervous while going to my village. When we reached, the principal was there already and was waiting for us. He was in full support of the idea of motivating students towards science and of showing them the beauty of science rather than just giving them textbook knowledge. He was with us the entire time and helped us with scientific *Marathi* words. Many teachers took videos of experiments from us to show the kids. I felt really happy as they were trying to improve the school and provide the students with the best they could. Also the support from the villagers and the positive response from the students enabled us to properly implement the program

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The moments we spent with children, how they hit our wickets in the very 1st ball they bowled, the dinner we had in one of their houses, and the smiles they had when they understood the logic behind an experiment, were the best and most touching moments of Spread The Smile.

By Suvidyakumar Homkar

In 'Spread the Smile' last year, I had a nice experience with the children in Kurunji's *Ashramshala*. But this time being a coordinator of the same village, it was very different.

Managing the volunteers, deciding on activities, and coordinating the teams each weekend was not a pleasant job. Still, when I saw that the children in Kurunji had not forgotten my name, I felt very awesome and I had a feeling that I was important for these children. This is a wonderful feeling.

'Spread the Smile' could have been better and I could have worked better, but still the experience has taught me a lot of things and has also given me more confidence in tackling many issues and problems.

By Prachi Atmasiddha

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Disha IISER Pune presents

Talk for Twenty

As can be inferred, talk for twenty offered a much wider spectrum of topics to be discussed, we will continue to hold such talks in future and everyone is very much welcomed to take the twenty minutes. However we are lacking volunteers who can help in strategic work like video editing, poster making etc.

By Himanshu Badhani



Weekend Program Report

We started weekend programme for those who were really enthusiastic in learning science and who couldn't get proper exposure to scientific instruments, labs and proper guidance. For the last one year we have been teaching some students from Sanjay Gandhi Vasahat and Laman Vasti, near IISER Pune campus. We demonstrated different science experiment and also explained the basic concepts of those. They also asked many questions related to these experiments. Many activities were designed to improve their communication skills. When we started this programme, very few students joined and



also the number of volunteers was not enough. But as we progressed, many children joined. Also there was increase in the number of volunteers.

We noticed that these kids were very shy and hence didn't want to perform on Stage. We decided to increase their

Stage daring by undertaking various activities like Drama Competition, Essay writing and debates on various topics related to their life. All these students had different qualities like, many of them liked dancing and some were good at sports. Some of them were also good at debating. We encouraged and helped them to improve their individual skills.

All the volunteers in weekend programme put their efforts in implementing different activities and also succeeded in it. I hope it keeps improving as time passes.

By Abhijeet Petkar



From President of Disha



Look around with open eyes and we see inequality of all sorts. What can be done to remove such inequalities, to bridge such a social gap? Awareness and exposure is an important component for progress. However, many children in our society all around us do not even have the opportunity to pursue many paths, due to lack of financial resources, of awareness and of proper guidance.

Should the financial status of parents or the facilities available in a particular region determine progress in one's life? Clearly the answer is no. But, how do we make about changes so that every child has the opportunity to succeed?

That is what Disha as an organization tries to address. The first step is trying to understand the problems. However, discussions and analysis is not going to help unless we proactively engage ourselves to apply such analyses to help underserved children.

Disha provides a platform to the youth to mentor underserved children in slums in Pune as well as villages around the city through voluntary work.

Disha has established two abhyasikas in Laman Vasti and Sanjay Gandhi Abhyasika to guide school students in their educational as well as co-curricular activities. For further mentorship of students in these vastis, Disha also organizes a weekend program; wherein stu-

"discussions and analysis is not going to help unless we proactively engage ourselves to apply such analyses to help underserved children."

dents visit IISER campus to study science experiments and maths games as well as take part in debates, drama and sports.

Disha organizes two Flagship programs: Vigyan Mela and Spread the Smile. Vigyan Mela is a two day event at the vastis to introduce students to a wide variety of mathematical and scientific avenues through fun filled

activities. Spread the Smile is a month long program for which volunteers visit nearby villages with fun-filled science experiments, art workshops and field activities designed to provide exposure and inspiration to village students.

Disha organizes 'Talk for twenty', a talk series intended to build awareness among IISER students about social problems and discuss solutions as well as initiatives by people to bring social change.

Disha is involved in teaching a student for 12th class competitive examinations as well as in a program Gyan Setu which organizes volunteer visits to underdeveloped states in the country.

Well, a seed has been planted in the form of these initiatives. A lot more needs to be done through consistent efforts so that students in our society have equal opportunities for success.

Real change is a slow and hard process. Working as a Disha volunteer is never an easy task but it is always worth the effort.

By Nishad Mandlik